🔍 The Developer's SEO Sauce

From Zero Visibility → Page 1 on Google

Using AI-Assisted Development + Post-Deployment Strategy

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Why Your Website Is Invisible on Google

You built it. You deployed it. You shared the link. And then... nothing. No traffic. No clicks. No ranking.

It's not a code bug. It's not your design. It's SEO — and 90% of developers skip it entirely during development.

This document gives you the complete playbook: what to do WHILE you're building (using AI tools like Claude, Cursor, Claude Code), and what to do AFTER you ship.

PART 1: SEO DURING DEVELOPMENT

1. Meta Tags — The Bare Minimum

Every page needs these inside <head>. Without them, Google has no idea what your page is about.

```
<!-- index.html / _document.tsx / layout.tsx -->
<title>Your App Name — Short Punchy Description</title>
<meta name="description" content="One-line pitch. Under 160 chars. Include
keyword.">
<meta name="keywords" content="keyword1, keyword2, keyword3">

<!-- Open Graph (for social sharing previews) -->
<meta property="og:title" content="Your App Name">
<meta property="og:description" content="Same or similar to meta description">
<meta property="og:image" content="https://yourdomain.com/og-image.png">
```

```
<meta property="og:url" content="https://yourdomain.com">
<meta property="og:type" content="website">

<!-- Twitter Card -->
<meta name="twitter:card" content="summary_large_image">
<meta name="twitter:title" content="Your App Name">
<meta name="twitter:image" content="https://yourdomain.com/og-image.png">
```

AI Prompt: *"Generate complete SEO meta tags for a SaaS called [name] that helps [target audience] do [thing]. Include OG tags and Twitter card."*

2. robots.txt — Tell Google What to Index

Place this file at the root of your domain: yourdomain.com/robots.txt

```
# Allow all crawlers to index the full site
User-agent: *
Allow: /

# Block admin and private routes from being indexed
Disallow: /admin/
Disallow: /api/
Disallow: /dashboard/
Disallow: /_next/

# Point to your sitemap
Sitemap: https://yourdomain.com/sitemap.xml
```

⚡ Why it matters

If you don't have robots.txt, Google may crawl your API routes, auth pages, and internal dashboards.

This wastes crawl budget and can expose sensitive route names. Always block /api/, /admin/, /auth/.

3. sitemap.xml — Your SEO Roadmap

A sitemap tells Google every page that exists on your site. Without it, Google discovers pages by following links — which is slow and incomplete.

```
<!-- sitemap.xml at root or generate dynamically -->
<?xml version="1.0" encoding="UTF-8"?>
<urlset xmlns="http://www.sitemaps.org/schemas/sitemap/0.9">
  <url>
    <loc>https://yourdomain.com/</loc>
    <lastmod>2026-01-01</lastmod>
```

```
    <changefreq>weekly</changefreq>
    <priority>1.0</priority>
  </url>
  <url>
    <loc>https://yourdomain.com/blog</loc>
    <lastmod>2026-01-01</lastmod>
    <changefreq>daily</changefreq>
    <priority>0.9</priority>
  </url>
  <!-- Add all public pages here -->
</urlset>
```

For Next.js, use the next-sitemap package. For Remix/Astro, generate it in a route handler. For any framework, ask your AI:

AI Prompt: *"Generate a dynamic sitemap.xml route for my Next.js 14 app that fetches all blog slugs from Supabase and includes static pages."*

4. Structured Data (JSON-LD) — Rich Snippets in Google

This is the secret weapon most developers don't know about. Structured data can give your result star ratings, FAQs, breadcrumbs, and more directly in search results.

```
<!-- Add in <head> or at end of <body> -->
<script type="application/ld+json">
{
  "@context": "https://schema.org",
  "@type": "SoftwareApplication",
  "name": "Your App Name",
  "applicationCategory": "BusinessApplication",
  "offers": {
    "@type": "Offer",
    "price": "0",
    "priceCurrency": "USD"
  },
  "description": "Short description of what your app does",
  "url": "https://yourdomain.com"
}
</script>

<!-- For Blog Posts -->
{
  "@type": "Article",
  "headline": "Post Title",
  "author": { "@type": "Person", "name": "Harshith" },
  "datePublished": "2026-01-01"
}
```

5. Semantic HTML — Structure Google Can Read

Google reads your HTML to understand page hierarchy. One H1 per page. Proper heading flow. Meaningful alt text on images.

```
<!-- ❌ Wrong -->
<div class="title">My App</div>
<div class="sub">Build faster with AI</div>

<!-- ✅ Correct -->
<h1>My App</h1>
<h2>Build faster with AI</h2>
<p>Detailed description with target keywords naturally included...</p>

<!-- Always add alt text to images -->
<img src="/hero.png" alt="AI-powered SaaS dashboard for social media automation"
/>

<!-- Use semantic elements -->
<main>, <article>, <section>, <nav>, <footer>, <aside>
```

6. Core Web Vitals — Speed = Rankings

Google uses LCP, FID/INP, and CLS as ranking signals. A slow site ranks lower, period.

Core Web Vitals Quick Reference

LCP (Largest Contentful Paint) → < 2.5s → Optimize hero images, use CDN
INP (Interaction to Next Paint) → < 200ms → Minimize JS blocking, lazy load
CLS (Cumulative Layout Shift) → < 0.1 → Set width/height on all images

AI Prompt: "Audit my Next.js page for Core Web Vitals issues and suggest fixes."

7. URL Structure — Keywords in Your URLs

```
❌ Bad:  /p?id=123
❌ Bad:  /post/a7f3b2c1
✅ Good: /blog/how-to-build-saas-with-ai
✅ Good: /tools/instagram-caption-generator

Rules:
- Use hyphens, not underscores
- Include your main keyword
- Keep it short and descriptive
- All lowercase
```

8. Canonical Tags — Avoid Duplicate Content

If your content is accessible via multiple URLs (with/without www, trailing slash, query params), Google may penalize you for duplicate content.

```
<!-- Add to every page's <head> -->
<link rel="canonical" href="https://yourdomain.com/current-page" />

<!-- In Next.js 14 App Router -->
export const metadata = {
  alternates: {
    canonical: 'https://yourdomain.com/current-page',
  },
}
```

PART 2: AI-POWERED SEO WITH CLAUDE CODE

Using Claude Code for SEO Automation

Claude Code can be extended with custom skills/instructions to act as your SEO co-pilot during development. Here's what to add to your CLAUDE.md or project instructions:

Claude Code SEO Skill Prompts

Add to your CLAUDE.md file

You are an SEO-aware full-stack developer. When creating or editing any page file:

1. Always add complete meta tags (title, description, OG, Twitter card)
2. Ensure exactly one H1 per page with target keyword
3. Add alt text to all images
4. Generate/update sitemap.xml entries
5. Add JSON-LD structured data appropriate to the page type
6. Use semantic HTML elements (main, article, section, nav)
7. Suggest slug/URL improvements for SEO if route name is non-descriptive
8. Flag any Core Web Vitals risks (large unoptimized images, layout shifts)

Geo-Targeted SEO with Claude Code

If your SaaS targets multiple regions or languages, instruct Claude Code to implement hreflang tags:

```
<!-- Instruct Claude Code with this: -->
"Add hreflang tags for en-US, en-IN, and en-GB to all pages.
Generate a locale-aware metadata function that sets canonical URL,
hreflang links, and og:locale based on the current locale param."
```

```
<!-- Output it generates: -->
<link rel="alternate" hreflang="en-us" href="https://yourdomain.com/en-us/page" />
<link rel="alternate" hreflang="en-in" href="https://yourdomain.com/en-in/page" />
<link rel="alternate" hreflang="x-default" href="https://yourdomain.com/page" />
```

Automated Blog Infrastructure

Blogs are your #1 long-term SEO weapon. Instruct Claude Code to scaffold this:

```
"Build a blog system with the following SEO requirements:
- Dynamic sitemap that auto-includes all blog slugs
- Article JSON-LD schema on each post
- Auto-generated meta description from first 160 chars of content
- Reading time estimate in page metadata
- Category pages with their own meta titles
- Internal linking suggestions (related posts)"
```

PART 3: POST-DEPLOYMENT SEO

Step 1: Google Search Console

This is mandatory. Free. And directly from Google. Do this the day you deploy.

→ Go to search.google.com/search-console
→ Add your domain property (DNS verification recommended)
→ Submit your sitemap.xml URL
→ Request indexing for your homepage and key pages
→ Monitor: Coverage errors, Core Web Vitals, Search queries, Click-through rates

📊 What to Watch in Search Console

Coverage → Are your important pages indexed? Any 404s or blocked URLs?
Performance → Which keywords are you appearing for? What's your CTR?
Core Web Vitals → Red URLs need immediate fixing
Links → Who is linking to you? Which pages have most internal links?

Step 2: Blogging Strategy — AI-Powered Content

One of the fastest ways to rank: write about trending topics in your niche right when they happen. Use this AI workflow:

```
Daily workflow (takes 20 mins):

1. Ask Claude: "What are the top 5 trending topics in [your niche] this week?
   Search for recent news and list them with search volume potential."

2. Pick the highest-relevance topic for your product

3. Ask Claude: "Write a 1200-word SEO blog post titled '[topic]'.
   Target keyword: [keyword]. Include:
   - Engaging intro that hooks the reader
   - Proper H2/H3 structure
   - FAQ section at the end (for featured snippets)
   - CTA linking to [your product]
   - JSON-LD Article schema"

4. Publish → Submit URL in Search Console → Share on Instagram
```

Step 3: Backlink Building

Backlinks = other websites linking to you. They're still the #1 ranking factor.

→ Submit to Product Hunt — generates massive backlinks and traffic
→ List on SaaS directories: alternativeto.net, g2.com, capterra.com, getapp.com
→ Submit to startup directories: betalist.com, startupstash.com
→ Write guest posts on dev blogs (hashnode, dev.to, medium)
→ Answer relevant questions on Reddit, Quora with link to your tool
→ Create a free tool/resource that people naturally link to

Step 4: Technical SEO Audit (Monthly)

```
Monthly Claude Audit Prompt:
"I'm running a monthly SEO audit for [yourdomain.com].
Audit checklist:
✓ All pages have unique title tags (50-60 chars)
✓ All pages have meta descriptions (150-160 chars)
✓ No broken internal links
✓ Images have alt text
✓ sitemap.xml is up to date
✓ robots.txt is correctly configured
✓ No duplicate content issues
✓ Core Web Vitals passing
Based on my codebase, identify any violations and suggest fixes."
```

Step 5: Keyword Research Using AI

```
Ask Claude:
"I'm building [product name] for [target audience].
Give me 20 keyword ideas organized by:
- High intent (ready to buy)
- Informational (blog content)
- Comparison (vs competitor content)
- Long-tail (specific, low competition)
Include estimated monthly search volume and difficulty for each."
```

QUICK REFERENCE CHECKLIST

✅ During Development	🚀 Post-Deployment
☐ Meta tags on every page	☐ Submit sitemap to Search Console
☐ robots.txt configured	☐ Request indexing for key pages
☐ sitemap.xml generated	☐ Publish 2+ blog posts/week
☐ Structured data (JSON-LD)	☐ Submit to 5+ directories
☐ Semantic HTML (H1, H2...)	☐ Build backlinks via guest posts
☐ Image alt text	☐ Monthly technical audit
☐ Canonical tags	☐ Monitor GSC weekly
☐ Clean URL slugs	☐ Track keyword rankings
☐ Core Web Vitals < 2.5s	☐ Internal link new posts to old
☐ hreflang (if multi-region)	☐ Update old posts with new info

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Here you go bud, Follow @buildwharsha on Instagram

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